

Writing a portion of a file being edited

The command to write a portion of the current file being edited to a new file is as follows:

```
:20,50 w > newfile.txt
```

As a result, the lines from 20 to 50 are written in a new file named *newfile.txt*. The above facility of processing parts of the text and substituting the original content with the output makes the Vi editor very powerful.

Inserting the output of a command executed within the Vi editor

Most users are familiar with the method to execute a shell command within the Vi editor. For example:

```
:! ls
```

Less known is the fact that you can insert the output of the command given within the Vi editor by placing a '.' (period) before the exclamation mark. For example, the following command will insert the current date into the file being edited, which can be used for documentation.

```
:.! date
```

Cursor movements

Vi editor has powerful cursor movement commands which, if mastered, can make editing faster.

H The cursor is positioned at the first line of the screen

M The cursor is positioned at the middle line of the screen

L The cursor is positioned at the last line of the screen

Scrolling through a file

The following commands can be used to scroll through a file.

Ctrl-f Scroll down by one screen

Ctrl-b Scroll up by one screen

Ctrl-u Scroll up by half a screen

Ctrl-d Scroll down by half a screen

zz Scroll the screen so that the current line appears at the middle of the screen.

The last one, *zz*, is very useful for viewing the block of code associated with the current line.

Editing a file opened without sudo

Let's assume that you are editing a file which requires root access and, as a result, you are unable to save it as you have not opened Vi editor in the *sudo* mode. So instead of saving the file by taking many steps, including saving it in a temporary file and copying it later, you can save it straight away by using a combination of the *tee* and *sudo* commands, as follows:

```
:w !sudo tee %!
```



Figure 1: Vi editor before *sort*



Figure 2: Vi editor after *sort*

You can refer to the link <http://www.geekyboy.com/archives/629> for details on how the above command works.

Powerful delete commands

Apart from the commonly used commands for deleting, the ones I found very useful are the following.

di{ Deletes all characters within the parentheses

di" Deletes all characters within the quotes

Shortcut to save and quit

Generally, we type *:wq* in the command mode to save the file and go to the command prompt. A shortcut for the same is as follows:

```
:x
```

Recovering a file

Lastly, the following command will help you to recover a file after a crash, from the swap file of the file being edited:

```
$vi -r filename
```

Practising these Vi tips will help you to increase your efficiency, and the side effect could be that you postpone the onset of RSI (repetitive stress injury)! 🙏🏻

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